

# Head Coverings For Women In Worship

prc-head-coverings-for-women-in-worship

Worship Structure · Symbolism · practice · minority\_lineages · brethren distinctive

**DISPUTED**

score 0.787  
confidence low

## Statement under examination

Paul's instruction in 1 Corinthians 11 about women covering their heads during prayer and prophecy in the gathered assembly continues to apply; the head-covering is a sign of the creation-order distinction Paul names there, applicable in the gathered assembly today (whether by literal covering or by another culturally-coherent sign of that distinction).

## In plain language

The words for covering and uncovering the head here, katakalupto and akatakaluptos, occur nowhere else in the whole Bible. So do the words for the woman having long hair and the hair itself, and the word for hair, kome, occurs only this once. Inside the chapter Paul does plainly tie a covering to women praying and prophesying. Verse 6 ends with a direct command form, let her be covered, and verse 6 also treats being shorn or shaved as a separate shameful thing from being uncovered, which suggests the covering is a cloth and not just the hair. He grounds the difference between man and woman in the creation account, and that ordering idea does appear elsewhere, in Genesis and again in another letter, so the underlying principle is not invented for one occasion. That part leans toward something lasting. But the chapter then shifts its footing. Paul appeals to nature, to long hair, to honor and shame, and to the custom of the churches, all words that can describe either a fixed order or a local sense of what is fitting. He says the hair is given to the woman in place of a covering, and the small word anti there usually means instead of, which would make the hair itself the covering and weaken the case for a separate cloth, though it can also mean corresponding to. The word for covering in that line, used only one other place in the Bible, means a garment there. There is also a hard line in verse 10 saying the woman should have authority on her head, where the word for authority everywhere else means power a person actually holds, not a sign of being under someone, so even the grammar resists a single reading. So the passage points two ways at once. The command and the creation grounding read as binding in its setting, but because the covering words appear only here, the hair word is a one-time word, and the key small words carry more than one attested sense, the language cannot settle whether the specific sign binds across all times and places. It is genuinely contested, and the deciding factors lie outside what word study and concordance can supply.

## Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

| Strong | Word          | Sounds like   | Plain meaning      | Times in Bible |
|--------|---------------|---------------|--------------------|----------------|
| G0177  | ἀκατακάλυπτος | akatakaluptos | uncovered          | 2              |
| G0473  | ἀντί          | anti          | for                | 22             |
| G1135  | γυνή          | gunē          | woman              |                |
| G1223  | διά           | dia           | through/because of |                |
| G1391  | δόξα          | doxa          | glory              | 167            |
| G1577  | ἐκκλησία      | ekklēsia      | assembly           |                |
| G1849  | ἐξουσία       | exousia       | authority          | 103            |

|              |             |              |                |    |
|--------------|-------------|--------------|----------------|----|
| <b>G2617</b> | καταισχύνω  | kataischyno  | to dishonor    | 13 |
| <b>G2619</b> | κατακαλύπτω | katakalypto  | to cover       | 3  |
| <b>G2751</b> | κείρω       | keiro        | to shear       | 4  |
| <b>G2776</b> | κεφαλή      | kephale      | head           | 76 |
| <b>G2863</b> | κομάω       | komao        | be long-haired | 2  |
| <b>G2864</b> | κόμη        | kome         | hair           | 1  |
| <b>G3587</b> | ξυράω       | xurao        | to shave       | 3  |
| <b>G3784</b> | ὀφείλω      | opheilo      | to owe         | 35 |
| <b>G4018</b> | περιβόλαιον | peribolaion  | covering       | 2  |
| <b>G4336</b> | προσεύχομαι | proseuchomai | to pray        | 86 |
| <b>G4395</b> | προφητεύω   | propheteuo   | to prophesy    | 28 |
| <b>G4914</b> | συνήθεια    | synetheia    | custom         | 3  |
| <b>G5449</b> | φύσις       | phusis       | nature         | 14 |

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

## Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

Inside 1 Corinthians 11 the instruction is explicit. katakalypto (G2619) and akatakalyptos (G0177) attach the covering to a woman praying or prophesying, verse 6 ends with the imperative katakalyptestho, the man-and-woman distinction is grounded in the creation sequence in verses 7 to 9, and verse 16 appeals to the practice of the churches, all of which read straightforwardly as a binding instruction in its setting. The trans-cultural reach is what the words leave open. The covering vocabulary (katakalypto, akatakalyptos, komao, kome, peribolaion) occurs only in this one passage, so its sense cannot be triangulated against the rest of the canon, kome (G2864) is a hapax, and verse 15 says the hair is given anti peribolaion, where anti (G0473) carries its dominant canonical sense instead of yet also a minor sense corresponding to, so it cannot be settled whether the hair replaces a cloth or parallels one. Because the creation-order PRINCIPLE is pan-canonical but the covering SIGN vocabulary is local and lexically ambiguous, the words sustain both a continuing and a culturally conditioned reading, leaving the proposition materially contested.

## Scripture

### 1Cor.11.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2776 κεφαλή, G2617 καταισχύνω, G4336 προσεύχομαι

Force. A man praying or prophesying with something down over his head (kata kephales echon, a thing on the head, not the hair) shames his head. The covering in view is a removable object, set in a paired contrast with the woman, and the trigger context is praying and prophesying, which in the surrounding chapters is gathered-assembly activity.

### 1Cor.11.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4395 προφητεύω, G0177 ἀκατακάλυπτος, G2617 καταισχύνω

Force. A woman praying or prophesying with her head uncovered (akatakalyptos) shames her head, the clause running parallel to the man clause, the shame likened to being shaved (exuremene). The text plainly attaches a covering distinction to the woman engaged in prayer and prophecy, supporting that a covering distinction is in view during worship. That the canon elsewhere has women prophesying (Acts 21.9, Acts 2.17) yet also has 1Cor.14.34 about women keeping silent shows the words do not by themselves fix the assembly setting.

### 1Cor.11.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2619 κατακαλύπτω, G2751 κείρω, G3587 ξυράω

Force. The verse runs an if-then chain that ends in the third person imperative katakalyptestho, let her be covered. Crucially it treats being shorn (keiro) or shaved (xurao) as a SEPARATE shameful alternative to not being covered, which presses toward the covering being a cloth distinct from the hair, since otherwise the not-covered woman and the shorn woman would describe the same act rather than two. The imperative mood is the strongest single grammatical signal that an instruction is given.

### 1Cor.11.7 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3784 όφείλω, G2776 κεφαλή, G1391 δόξα

Force. The man ought not (opheilo, obligation language) to cover his head because he is the image and glory (doxa) of God, while the woman is the glory of man. The obligation verb and the image-and-glory grounding push toward a non-arbitrary distinction. The grounding is given as the reason for the practice, not as an explicit statement that the cloth itself binds in every culture.

### 1Cor.11.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1223 διά, G1135 γυνή

Force. The woman was created for the sake of (dia plus accusative) the man, echoing the Genesis sequence. The dia clause anchors the man-and-woman distinction in creation rather than in a passing local fashion, and the same creation-order argument recurs at 1Tim.2.13, so the underlying PRINCIPLE is attested beyond this passage even though the covering sign is not.

### 1Cor.11.10 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1849 εξουσία, G2776 κεφαλή

Force. The woman ought to have exousia (G1849) on her head, because of the angels. Across all 103 canonical uses exousia means power or authority that one actively holds or exercises, never elsewhere a passive token of being under authority. Read by its normal sense the clause says the woman has authority on her own head, which sits oddly with the subordination logic of verses 7 to 9, so interpreters must either supply an unattested sense (a sign of authority over her) or take it at face value. This is a genuine grammatical and lexical knot the passage does not resolve in its own words.

### 1Cor.11.14 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5449 φύσις, G2863 κομάω

Force. Paul appeals to phusis (nature, G5449) and asks whether nature teaches that long hair (komao) on a man is a dishonor. Across the canon phusis can mean fixed created order (Rom.1.26, Rom.2.14) or ingrained disposition and custom, and the vocabulary here does not state which sense governs, so grounding the argument in phusis and in honor and shame is the lexical signal most often read as time-and-place conditioned, which complicates a strictly perpetual reading.

### 1Cor.11.15 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0473 αντί, G2864 κόμη, G4018 περιβόλαιον

Force. The hair (kome, a hapax) is given to the woman anti peribolaion. The preposition anti (G0473) in its dominant canonical sense means instead of or in exchange for (eye for eye Matt.5.38, ransom for many Mark.10.45, evil for evil Rom.12.17), with only a minor corresponding-to sense, and peribolaion (G4018) in its one other canonical use, Heb.1.12, plainly means a garment or wrap likened to a cloak. If anti means instead of, the chapter supplies its own covering through the hair and weakens the case for a separate cloth. If it means corresponding to, the hair merely parallels a cloth the woman should also wear. Morphology alone cannot decide, and this is the central lexical ambiguity of the passage.

## 1Cor.11.16 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4914 συνήθεια, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Force. Paul closes by appealing to synetheia (custom, G4914) and the practice of the churches, saying neither we nor the churches of God have such a custom. synetheia occurs only three times in the canon (here, 1Cor.8.7 of an ingrained habit of conscience, John.18.39 of a local Passover custom), so its attested range covers both ingrained habit and settled communal usage. Closing on custom and corporate practice rather than on a bare standalone command is read by some as anchoring the matter in shared apostolic usage that continues and by others as locating it in adjustable church custom, which keeps the permanence question open.

## Cross references invoked

| From       | To         | Source    | Votes |
|------------|------------|-----------|-------|
| 1Cor.11.7  | Gen.2.18   | openbible | 31    |
| 1Cor.11.7  | Gen.1.26   | openbible | 22    |
| 1Cor.11.7  | Gen.1.27   | openbible | 21    |
| 1Cor.11.3  | Gen.3.16   | openbible | 19    |
| 1Cor.11.3  | Eph.5.23   | openbible | 14    |
| 1Cor.11.3  | 1Cor.14.34 | openbible | 11    |
| 1Cor.11.8  | Gen.2.22   | openbible | 18    |
| 1Cor.11.8  | 1Tim.2.13  | openbible | 12    |
| 1Cor.11.5  | 1Cor.14.34 | openbible | 13    |
| 1Cor.11.5  | Gen.24.65  | openbible | 3     |
| 1Cor.11.10 | Gen.24.65  | openbible | 2     |
| 1Cor.11.6  | Num.5.18   | tsk       | 1     |
| 1Cor.11.5  | Deut.21.12 | tsk       | 1     |
| 1Cor.11.14 | 2Sam.14.26 | tsk       | 1     |

## Complicating texts

### 1Cor.11.15 · addressed

The phrase anti peribolaion turns on the preposition anti (G0473) and the noun peribolaion (G4018). Across the canon anti most often means instead of or in exchange for, but it also carries a corresponding-to sense in a minority of constructions, and peribolaion in its only other occurrence (Heb.1.12) clearly denotes a garment. Morphology alone cannot decide which sense of anti governs here, so the verse legitimately supports both a hair-is-the-covering reading and a hair-corresponds-to-the-covering reading. The hapax status of kome (G2864) removes any second context for triangulating the image. This irreducible ambiguity is recorded as a driver of the disputed verdict rather than resolved against the text.

### 1Cor.11.14 · addressed

The appeal to phusis (G5449) and to honor and shame categories is a principal complicating signal for permanence. phusis is attested across the canon for both fixed created order and ingrained custom, and the vocabulary does not state which is meant here, so it neither secures nor refutes perpetual application. It is retained as a genuine tension feeding the disputed verdict.

## 1Cor.11.16 · addressed

The closing appeal to synetheia (G4914) and to the practice of the churches can be read either as grounding the matter in shared apostolic usage that continues or as locating it in adjustable church custom. The three canonical uses of synetheia span ingrained habit and communal usage, so the lexical data alone does not adjudicate between these readings, and the verse is logged as unresolved tension contributing to the disputed verdict.

## 1Cor.11.10 · unaddressed

The clause that the woman ought to have exousia (G1849) on her head because of the angels is not resolved by the lexical data. exousia in all other canonical uses means actively held power, not a passive symbol of submission, so the natural sense (the woman has authority on her head) clashes with the subordination grounding of verses 7 to 9, and the meaning of because of the angels has no concordance support to fix it. No reading is foreclosed and none is secured by the words, so this is left as an open lexical and grammatical knot rather than resolved.

## Concordance traversed

G2619, G0177, G2863, G2864, G4018, G0473, G2776, G1849, G4914, G5449, G2617, G3784, G4395, G4336, G2751, G3587, G1391

## Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units were supplied in the bundle for 1 Corinthians 11, and 1 Corinthians is outside the published ECM 3 John sample, so any apparatus reading here is shadow status. The editorial marks in the supplied text at verses 2, 3, 5, 7, 10, 11, 14, 15 touch word order and minor pronoun and article readings that do not move the verdict, since the contested terms katakalypto, akatakalyptos, anti, peribolaion, kome, and exousia are textually stable in the supplied text.

## Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. creation\_order, cultural\_accommodation, new\_covenant\_practice

analogia scripturae invoked

creation\_order: leans for · Verses 7 to 9 ground the sex distinction in the Genesis creation sequence through the dia clause and the image-and-glory language, the cross-reference net to Gen.1.26, Gen.1.27, Gen.2.18, and Gen.2.22 is dense and high-vote, and the same Genesis-order argument recurs at 1Tim.2.13, so the man-and-woman ordering PRINCIPLE reads as a trans-temporal basis. On this lens the sign attaches to that lasting order and the proposition leans toward continuing application, including a culturally coherent equivalent of the sign.

cultural\_accommodation: leans against · Verses 13 to 16 ground the argument in phusis, in long hair as komao and kome, in honor and shame, and in the synetheia of the churches, all vocabulary whose attested range includes time-and-place conditioned propriety. Read this way the specific cloth covering is a culturally coded sign of the underlying distinction, so the external form need not bind today even if the distinction it signified does. The dominant instead-of sense of anti in verse 15 reinforces this lens by letting the hair itself stand as the God-given covering.

new\_covenant\_practice: insufficient · The covering vocabulary (katakalypto, akatakalyptos, komao, kome, peribolaion) does not recur anywhere else in the New Testament, kome is a hapax, and peribolaion appears only once more in a non-covering context. There is no second corporate-practice text using these words against which to test whether the apostolic churches treated the covering as a perpetual ordinance or a local arrangement, so the permanence of the specific sign is lexically underdetermined.

The analogia scripturae check cuts two ways and is the heart of the dispute. The man-and-woman ordering PRINCIPLE is genuinely pan-canonical (Gen.1 to Gen.3, 1Tim.2.13, Eph.5.23, Col.3.18, 1Pet.3.1), so comparing Scripture with Scripture supports the distinction Paul names. But the covering SIGN vocabulary is confined to this

one passage, so the same principle supplies almost no independent material for the external sign itself. The verdict therefore separates a well-attested principle from a locally-attested and lexically ambiguous sign.

## Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Examine whether the head-covering instruction in 1 Corinthians 11 about women praying and prophesying is presented as binding on the gathered assembly beyond the original setting, and on what basis (creation order, nature, or church custom) the text grounds the sign.

The proposition embeds its conclusion in two ways. First, it asserts that the instruction continues to apply, which is the contested question rather than a given. Second, it pre-interprets the sign as one of the creation-order distinction Paul names and then broadens it to whether by literal covering or by another culturally-coherent sign, which already concedes a substitution the text does not explicitly authorize. The verdict was derived on the original stem, and the neutralized form strips the continues-to-apply and culturally-coherent-substitute framing so the lexical data can speak. The verdict remains disputed, unchanged from the prior file, now supported by additional queried data (exousia and peribolaion distributions, the kome hapax, the dominant instead-of sense of anti, and the pan-canonical reach of the creation-order principle versus the local reach of the covering vocabulary).

## Citations

| Type        | Source               | License       | Redist. | Ref        |
|-------------|----------------------|---------------|---------|------------|
| lexicon     | STEPBible-TBESG      | CC-BY-4.0     | yes     | G2619      |
| lexicon     | STEPBible-TBESG      | CC-BY-4.0     | yes     | G0177      |
| lexicon     | STEPBible-TBESG      | CC-BY-4.0     | yes     | G1849      |
| lexicon     | STEPBible-TBESG      | CC-BY-4.0     | yes     | G4018      |
| lexicon     | STEPBible-TBESG      | CC-BY-4.0     | yes     | G0473      |
| morphology  | MorphGNT-morphology  | CC-BY-SA-4.0  | yes     | 1Cor.11.6  |
| interlinear | STEPBible-TAGNT      | CC-BY-4.0     | yes     | 1Cor.11.15 |
| cross_ref   | OpenBible-cross-refs | CC-BY         | yes     | 1Cor.11.7  |
| cross_ref   | TSK                  | public_domain | yes     | 1Cor.11.5  |

## License audit

SAFE TO PUBLISH

| Source               | License       | Redistribute |
|----------------------|---------------|--------------|
| STEPBible-TBESG      | CC-BY-4.0     | yes          |
| MorphGNT-morphology  | CC-BY-SA-4.0  | yes          |
| STEPBible-TAGNT      | CC-BY-4.0     | yes          |
| OpenBible-cross-refs | CC-BY         | yes          |
| TSK                  | public_domain | yes          |

## Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow · complicating-unresolved